

THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

 A liquefied-natural-gas carrier at sea

Source: Wikimedia Commons — "File:LNG tanker Christophe de Margerie.jpg." A liquefied-natural-gas carrier — the fuel a widening Gulf war reached this week (p3), and the reason a Singapore power bill rose 17% (p5). Representative.

THE WORLD

Washington answers the salvo with a “heavy wave” — and the war widens to Egypt, where a drone sets a gas terminal alight

THE MACRO DESK

A hawkish Fed, a hawkish Bank of Japan, a widening war — and the dollar falls, because the tape is listening to the cloud

SINGAPORE

Energy enters the trade ministry’s name — and the next week, a 17% power bill puts the reason on the reader’s account

THIS ISSUE · THE WEEKDAY BRIEFING

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FROM THE DESK

"Safety and certainty in oil lie in variety, and variety alone."

— Winston Churchill, House of Commons, 17 July 1913¹

The issue runs on one fuel line: a war widening over gas (p3), a Singapore power bill up 17% (p5), a cloud boom measured in megawatts (p15). The essay (p21) reaches to 1911, when Churchill ran the Navy on oil it didn't have. His answer — variety, and variety alone — is the same word the Macro desk gives the reader's own portfolio.

THE STRIP — AT THURSDAY'S CLOSE

LEVEL	30 JUL
Brent crude	~\$90
Gold (XAU)	~\$4,100
Bitcoin	~\$64.5k
US 10-Year	~4.65%
DXY	~99.9
USD/JPY	~163.6
BoJ rate	1.00%
AWS growth	+37%

Indicative levels around the 30 Jul close; see The Macro Desk (p15).²

THE MERIDIAN INDEX

Share of Singapore's electricity made from imported natural gas, per cent: **95** — p5

Rise in the household power tariff this quarter, per cent: **17** — p5

Brent's one-day jump after the US "heavy wave," per cent: **7.9** — p3

Growth in Amazon's data-centre cloud revenue in a quarter, per cent: **37** — p15

Stake in the Anglo-Persian Oil Company Britain bought in 1914 to fuel its navy, per cent: **51** — p21

Level of the US dollar index, in a week it was "supposed" to rise: **99.9** — p15

Rank of the best open-weight AI model on earth, out of 189: **3** — p7

That model's hallucination rate, per cent: **51** — p7

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Social-media accounts Australia says its under-16 ban has closed, millions: **4.7** — p13

Width of one distant black hole's wind, in light-years: **300,000** — p16

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Nights of BTS in Singapore this December, all sold out: **4** — p19

Minutes of strength work a week linked to the longest life: **90–120** — p18

Bank of Japan's policy rate held this week, per cent: **1.00** — p15

SOURCES ¹ Winston Churchill, House of Commons, 17 July 1913 (Hansard / Churchill Archives) — see The Long Read, pp21–23. ² Market strip — indicative levels around the 30 Jul 2026 close: Trading Economics / Yahoo Finance / Forbes / CoinGecko / Fed H.15 / Bitcoin.com; Brent ~\$90; gold ~\$4,100; BTC ~\$64.5k; US 10Y ~4.65%; DXY ~99.9 (dollar eased); USD/JPY ~163.6; BoJ held 1.00%; Amazon AWS +37% YoY. See The Macro Desk (p15). The Meridian Index harvests numbers from this issue; each is footnoted to its desk.

THE WORLD • THE GULF

The Beating Lands, and the War Finds Egypt

Washington answered the missile salvo with a “heavy wave” on the Revolutionary Guard; Tehran vowed to punish the aggressor the same day; and for the first time the fighting reached Egypt, where a drone set a gas terminal alight. The barrel jumped eight per cent — then faded. The market is still betting the strait stays open.

The beating No. 57 saw Trump promise arrived on schedule. Late on 29 July, US Central Command completed what officials called a “heavy wave” — a roughly two-hour operation against dozens of Revolutionary Guard targets, command centres and drone facilities, in answer to the ballistic-missile salvo fired days earlier at American forces in Jordan.¹ By Thursday the Guard had its reply ready in words: it “will punish the aggressor today,” and warned that any country aiding the United States would “receive a harsh response.” The exchange the Muscat talks were meant to prevent is now a fortnight old and hardening.

What makes this a widening rather than another round is the map. For the first time the war touched Egypt: a drone strike set a fire at the port of Damietta, damaging two gas carriers and disrupting one of the eastern Mediterranean’s key liquefied-gas hubs — no party claimed it.² Iran’s navy said it struck

three commercial ships near Hormuz on Thursday, among them a Marshall Islands-flagged tanker, though Baghdad insisted the vessels sat in Iraqi waters.³ The dead crossed borders too — a family killed on Qeshm, a worker killed at a Chinese-owned site in Kuwait, Guard advisers buried in Iraq. The barrel’s read is on p15; the gas price’s reaches all the way to a Singapore electricity bill (p5).

+7.9%

BRENT’S ONE-DAY JUMP ON THE “HEAVY WAVE,” TO NEAR \$91 — THEN IT EASED BACK BELOW THAT THE NEXT SESSION. THE WAR WIDENED; THE OIL MARKET DECLINED TO CHASE IT.

The war found a new front in Egypt. The oil price, strangely, refused to follow it.

WAR WIDENS

EGYPT HIT

OIL ROUND-TRIPS

WASHINGTON — CENTCOM / THE WHITE HOUSE

“IT’S OUR TURN”

The White House casts the heavy wave as a promised reply to an attempted ambush, aimed at the Guard and its proxies rather than the Iranian state. The ladder’s next rung stays, for now, in American hands — and the careful part of the message is what it still withholds. No strike yet on Tehran itself, none yet on the oil fields. So far Washington is hitting Iran’s reach, not its heart, and keeping the option of stopping.

BEIJING — THE FOREIGN MINISTRY

“MILITARY MEANS CANNOT SOLVE IT”

Mao Ning urged both sides back to the memorandum they signed and away from force, and dismissed as “false and entirely unfounded” a report that China would ship air-defence launchers to Iran. Beijing’s stake turned concrete this week: one of the dead in Kuwait worked for a Chinese firm, and close to a fifth of the oil China imports moves through the water now under fire. Its call is for the corridor, not either combatant.

THE SCEPTIC

The tell is the tape. A US heavy wave, fresh tanker hits and a gas terminal ablaze in Egypt — and Brent fell the following session. If traders genuinely feared Hormuz closing, the barrel would be extending through \$90, not fading it; the market is still pricing an attritional war with the strait broadly open. The casualty counts on both sides are single-outlet and provisional. The escalation is real. The oil shock, for now, is a threat the price does not yet believe.

SOURCES 1 U.S. News; The Hill; Times of Israel, 29–30 Jul 2026 (US Central Command completed a “heavy wave” ~29 Jul, a ~2-hour operation against dozens of IRGC targets — command centres and drone facilities — after the intercepted ballistic-missile salvo on US forces at Muwaffaq Salti, Jordan; IRGC “will punish the aggressor today,” a “harsh response” to any state aiding the US, 30 Jul). 2 CNN; CBS News, 30 Jul (drone attack on the port of Damietta, Egypt — a fire, two gas carriers damaged, a key eastern-Mediterranean LNG hub disrupted; no claim of responsibility). 3 CNBC; AOL, 30 Jul (Iran’s navy says it struck three commercial ships near Hormuz — the Marshall Islands-flagged Safesee Vishnu and Maltese-flagged Zefyros among them; Iraq’s state oil company says they were in Iraqi waters; casualties — a family on Qeshm, a worker at a Chinese-owned site in Kuwait, IRGC advisers in Iraq — single-outlet and provisional); Global Times; Washington Institute, 29–30 Jul (Mao Ning: “military means cannot solve the fundamental issue,” urging a return to the MOU; China calls the arms-transfer report “false and entirely unfounded”). Oil: Trading Economics; Forbes, 30 Jul (Brent +~7.9% on 29 Jul toward ~\$90.66, then eased below \$91 on 30 Jul to ~\$90; WTI ~\$84).

THE WORLD • AROUND THE DESKS

An Emergency in Kyiv, a Count That Won't Stall, a Clock Moves Indoors in Cali

While the Gulf widened, the other wars kept their own clocks. In Ukraine the delta was demand. The 28 July Zelensky-Trump readout held — talk of licences to co-produce Patriot interceptors in Europe, of reviving the Russia track — but the fact on the ground moved the other way: Russia has expanded its near-daily bombardment of Ukrainian cities to exploit Kyiv's interceptor shortage, and Zelensky has now asked Washington for an emergency Patriot package.¹ The Senate advanced the Graham sanctions bill (No. 57's 86-12). The promised Witkoff-Kushner visit to Kyiv still has no date.

In the Democratic Republic of Congo, the Bundibugyo Ebola outbreak still would not plateau. The count to 27 July reached 3,360 confirmed cases and 1,487 deaths — up from the 3,262 and 1,437 No. 57 carried — with Ituri province alone at 2,988 cases and 1,238 deaths.² It remains both the largest Bundibugyo outbreak ever documented and the fastest-growing Ebola outbreak on record, still without a licensed vaccine. One piece of good news: Uganda declared its own smaller outbreak over on 28 July. In a conflict zone the tracking lags the disease — the real figure is likelier under-counted than over.

3,360

CONFIRMED DRC EBOLA CASES TO 27 JUL (1,487 DEATHS), UP +98/+50 ON THE WEEK — THE LARGEST BUNDIBUGYO OUTBREAK EVER, AND THE FASTEST-GROWING EBOLA OUTBREAK ON RECORD. UGANDA DECLARED ITS CLUSTER OVER 28 JUL.

The Gulf widened. The other wars kept their casualties and their clocks — one of them, at last, closing.

IN BRIEF — AROUND THE WORLD

Cali: Colombia's handover clock reads a week, and the ceremony itself has become the fight. President-elect Abelardo de la Espriella — who won the 21 June runoff ~49.66% to Iván Cepeda's 48.70% — will be sworn in on 7 August not in Bogotá but indoors at an arena in Cali, after Congress authorised moving the oath; Petro says he will not attend.³ His 17 July suit to annul the result has published no evidence; the guest list already runs to Milei, Noboa and Spain's King Felipe VI.

Southern Europe burns: France and Spain fight fresh wildfires in a 42°C heatwave — the summer's heat pattern, on schedule.

THE CHATTER

Ukraine-watchers read the emergency Patriot ask, not the coproduction line, as the meeting's real signal: the interceptors Kyiv is promised for later do nothing about the missiles arriving tonight, and Moscow is timing its raids to the gap. The optimistic read — a channel to Kyiv finally open — runs into the old wall: a promised visit with no date is a plan, not a policy.

— The Hill; Defense News; Al Jazeera, 28–29 Jul 2026

THE SCEPTIC

Two asterisks. On Ukraine, a Patriot package promised is not a Patriot package delivered — count the launchers on Ukrainian soil, not the licences discussed in Washington. On Colombia, the base case is still a peaceful transfer on 7 August: a suit with no published evidence against a count observers accept is very unlikely to stop the swearing-in. The risk is the temperature of the handover, not its fact.

SOURCES | The Hill; Defense News; Al Jazeera, 28–29 Jul 2026 (Zelensky-Trump readout “good”; Patriot interceptor coproduction-licence discussion; Russia expands near-daily city bombardment to exploit Kyiv's interceptor shortage; Zelensky asks for an emergency Patriot package; Senate advanced the Graham “Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act,” No. 57's 86–12; no confirmed Witkoff/Kushner Kyiv date). 2 WHO DON612 / AFRO SitRep 11 + ECDC, data to 26–27 Jul (DRC 3,360 cases / 1,487 deaths, up +98/+50 from 3,262/1,437; Ituri 2,988/1,238; largest Bundibugyo outbreak on record, fastest-growing Ebola outbreak; Uganda declared its outbreak over 28 Jul, 12 days after last discharge; UN names Julien Harneis coordinator); NPR, 29 Jul. 3 Colombia One; Bogotá Post; MercoPress, 22–29 Jul (De la Espriella won the 21 Jun runoff ~49.66% to Cepeda's 48.70%; inauguration 7 Aug moved indoors to an arena in Cali after Congress authorised relocating the oath; Petro will not attend; his Council-of-State annulment suit filed 17 Jul, no evidence published; attendees to include Milei, Noboa, Peña, Fujimori, King Felipe VI). Wildfires: NPR World, 28–29 Jul (42°C heatwave).

SINGAPORE • ENERGY

The First Bill Under the New Name

A week after energy entered the trade ministry's title, the number that makes the point lands on the reader's own account: household electricity is up 17 per cent this quarter, to 31.91 cents a unit — and the reason runs straight back to the gas ships burning off Egypt (p3).

The reshuffle of 27 July put “energy” into the Ministry of Trade and Industry's name for the first time — from October it becomes the Ministry of Energy, Trade and Industry.¹ The rename read as positioning. Then the bill arrived to make it concrete: for July to September the regulated household tariff rose 17 per cent — 4.64 cents a unit — to 31.91 cents before GST, roughly seventeen dollars a month more on a four-room flat.²

Where the increase comes from is the whole argument for the rename. Singapore makes about ninety-five per cent of its electricity from imported natural gas, and the regulated tariff tracks the fuel price with a lag; that price has climbed as the Middle East conflict strains global LNG shipping — the same disruption that this week set a gas terminal alight in Egypt and put tankers under fire near Hormuz (p3).³ An island that imports almost all its fuel now grows

an AI-and-data-centre economy whose appetite is electricity. Where the growth comes from and where the power comes from have become one question — which is what a ministry puts in its title when it wants the country to notice. The portfolio read is on p15.

+17%

THE HOUSEHOLD ELECTRICITY TARIFF FOR JUL–SEP, TO 31.91¢/KWH — ABOUT S\$17 MORE A MONTH ON A FOUR-ROOM FLAT, TRACKING IMPORTED-GAS PRICES LIFTED BY THE GULF.

The ministry put “energy” in its name. The next week, the grid put the reason on the reader's bill.

POWER +17%

IMPORTED-GAS GRID

ENERGY IN THE TITLE

ALSO ON THE ISLAND

NDP, indoors and imminent: the 61st National Day Parade returns to the National Stadium on 9 August for the first time in a decade — a first-ever indoor drone show of 300-plus craft — and runs its second preview tomorrow, 1 August.⁴

The tariff, with exemptions: the US 12.5% Section-301 duty has stood since 24 July, but technology and Section-232 lines — smartphones, laptops, semiconductors — are carved out, sparing most of the export mix; MAS has not moved.⁵

THE CHATTER

The household read on r/singapore was less about the ministry than the meter: a 17 per cent jump arriving in the same window as a renamed “energy” portfolio struck people as either bad timing or honest signalling. The careful take is the second — the bill is the clearest evidence yet that Singapore's growth story and its electricity story are now the same file, and that the file has a price.

— r/singapore, aggregated; MissLobang, Jun–Jul 2026

THE SCEPTIC

Do not over-read the coincidence. The tariff runs on a fuel-cost formula that has swung both ways for years — it can fall next quarter as mechanically as it rose — and the rename is a signal, not yet an instrument: no import deal, no generation contract, no budget line has been booked under the new name. A word in a ministry's title and a formula-driven bill are evidence of attention, not of a solution. Watch the October budget.

SOURCES 1 Prime Minister's Office, Jul 2026 (pmo.gov.sg); line-up effective 27 Jul; Jeffrey Sioe, David Neo, Sim Ann to full Minister; K. Shanmugam to Senior Minister, retaining Home Affairs & National Security; MTI renamed the Ministry of Energy, Trade and Industry, effective 1 Oct 2026. 2 SP Group media release; Mothership; MissLobang, Jun 2026 (household electricity tariff up 17.0% / 4.64¢/kWh for 1 Jul–30 Sep 2026, to 31.91¢/kWh before GST — 34.78¢ with GST; –S\$17/month more on a 4-room HDB flat). 3 EMA / SP Group (the regulated tariff tracks fuel costs with a lag; ~95% of Singapore's electricity is generated from imported natural gas; gas prices lifted by Middle East conflict straining global LNG shipping incl. the Strait of Hormuz) — cf. The World, p3. 4 ndp.gov.sg; Time Out SG (61st NDP, 9 Aug, back at the National Stadium after ~10 years; first indoor drone show, 300+ drones; Preview 2 on 1 Aug). 5 MTI media statement; TNGlobal; Morgan Lewis, 23–24 Jul (US Section 301 12.5% ad valorem effective 24 Jul; Section-232/technology products — smartphones, laptops, semiconductors — exempt; MAS unchanged). Q2 GDP held +5.7% y/y (No. 57).

PROPERTY • THE RESALE MARKET

Two Speeds in One Quarter

The HDB resale index fell for a second straight quarter — and in the same three months a record 491 flats changed hands above a million dollars. A cooling average and a heating ceiling are the same market now — which is why last week's wait-out removal looks less like a gamble.

The second-quarter numbers describe a market pulling apart. The HDB Resale Price Index slipped 0.3 per cent to 202.7 — its first back-to-back quarterly fall in about seven years — while the same quarter set a record 491 resale flats sold above a million dollars, up nearly a fifth and 7.7 per cent of all resale deals.¹ Private prices told the same story: the URA index rose just 0.5 per cent while unsold uncompleted inventory thinned 7.2 per cent.² The average is cooling; the ceiling is not.

That split reframes last week's policy. When Chee Hong Tat scrapped the fifteen-month wait-out for private owners buying non-subsidised HDB resale flats (No. 57), the fear was a fresh wave of cash-rich downsizers bidding prices back up. This week the analysts closed ranks against it: ERA's Eugene Lim

called the removal “measured,” PropNex's Kelvin Fong “well-judged,” both arguing a spike is unlikely because supply, not this one demand valve, drives resale prices.³ The counted supply backs them — some 13,480 flats reach their minimum-occupation period in 2026, nearly double last year's, atop a record 9,320-unit land pipeline. And the froth is off the private launches: Lentor Gardens booked just 54 per cent on day one, against the 90-plus-per-cent sell-outs of the spring.⁴

491

MILLION-DOLLAR HDB RESALE FLATS IN Q2 — A RECORD, +19.5% ON THE QUARTER — PRINTED WHILE THE RESALE INDEX FELL 0.3%. A COOLING AVERAGE WITH A HEATING TOP END.

TWO-SPEED MARKET

RPI -0.3%

RECORD M\$ FLATS

THE SUPPLY SIDE

A S\$2.1b bet outside the CBD: a Frasers-led consortium bid S\$2.128b (~S\$1,323 psf ppr) for the Bayshore Drive site — ~1,280 homes on the future Bedok South MRT, the first S\$2b non-CBD state-land sale; the formal URA award is due early-to-mid August.⁵

Pipeline full: 9,320 GLS units for the year (over half above the ten-year average), October's BTO ~7,970 flats, and 13,480 reaching MOP.⁴

THE CHATTER

The HardwareZone and r/singapore threads split the way the data does. Private downsizers cheered the wait-out's removal; first-timers posted the anxiety — cash-rich buyers, mature-estate four-room flats bid out of reach. The record 491 gives that fear a number, even as the falling index tells the median buyer the opposite.

— r/singapore; HardwareZone forums, 28 Jul 2026

THE SCEPTIC

The consensus that prices “won't spike” is a claim about the average, and the average is not where the risk lives. Eugene Lim's own earlier caution stands: thin mature-estate four-room supply meeting cash-rich downsizers can push that niche higher even as the index falls — 254 million-dollar four-room deals this year against 93 a year earlier. So: broadly flat, with a hot ceiling the removal could lift further. The repeal is low-cost optics — responsive-looking, risking little in the aggregate, more than nothing at the top.¹

SOURCES 1 EdgeProp; 99.co; Stacked Homes, 24 Jul 2026 (HDB RPI -0.3% to 202.7 in Q2, second straight quarterly fall, first back-to-back in ~7 years; record 491 million-dollar resale flats, +19.5% q/q, 7.7% of resale deals, 4-room led at 212; YTD 254 million-dollar 4-room deals vs 93 a year earlier). 2 URA pr26-57, 24 Jul (private PPI +0.5% q/q in Q2, H1 +1.4%; landed +2.6%, non-landed -0.1%; unsold uncompleted inventory 14,929 ex-EC, -7.2% q/q) — via PropNex / EdgeProp; URA page 403 in-sandbox. 3 The Edge Singapore; 99.co, 28 Jul (ERA's Eugene Lim “measured”; PropNex's Kelvin Fong “well-judged”; Huttons — a spike “unlikely”; supply, not the removal, the dominant force). 4 Straits Times via Yahoo SG (13,480 flats reach MOP in 2026, ~2× 2025's 6,970); CBRE, 3 Jun (GLS 2H2026 Confirmed 4,745 units, 9,320 full-year, >50% above the 10-yr average; Oct BTO ~7,970); ERA / 99.co (Lentor Gardens 270/499 = 54% day-one, avg ~S\$2,350 psf) — take-up single-cluster, flagged. 5 Stacked Homes; EdgeProp (Bayshore Drive, Frasers-led JV, S\$2.128b = ~S\$1,323 psf ppr, ~1,280 homes + retail, Bedok South MRT; first S\$2b non-CBD site; tender closed 15 Jul, formal award early-to-mid Aug).

TECHNOLOGY · SILICON & SOVEREIGNTY

It Answers More — and Invents More

Kimi K3's independent scores are in: third or fourth of 189 models, Opus-4.8-class, at a third of the price. The same testing found the catch — a hallucination rate that climbed to 51 per cent. The best open model in the world is also, by this measure, the most confidently wrong.

When Moonshot's Kimi K3 weights went live late on 26 July, the only charts were the maker's own. The independent numbers arrived this week, and they are startling. Artificial Analysis ranks K3 third-to-fourth of 189 models on its Intelligence Index at about 57 — level with Claude Opus 4.8 and GPT-5.5, behind only Fable 5 and GPT-5.6 Sol — and cheaply, live across nine API providers day-zero at US\$3 and US\$15 per million tokens, about \$0.94 a benchmark task against \$1.80 for Opus 4.8.¹ An openly-downloadable Chinese model now sits inside the top four on Earth.

The same evaluation carried the catch, and Moonshot's charts left it out. On the Omniscience test K3 answers far more correctly than its predecessor — accuracy up from 33 to 46 per cent — but its hallucination rate rose alongside, from 39 on K2.6 to about 51 per cent.² A model that learned to answer more has also learned to invent more. A distillation cloud hangs over it besides: a US science-policy official alleged Moonshot trained K3 on Anthropic's Claude — the model reportedly self-

identifies as "Claude" — an accusation Moonshot has not answered and researchers call unproven.³

#3-4

K3'S RANK AMONG 189 MODELS ON THE INDEPENDENT ARTIFICIAL ANALYSIS INDEX (~57) — OPUS-4.8-CLASS, AT ABOUT A THIRD OF THE COST.

The best open model in the world is also, by this measure, the most confidently wrong.

VERDICT IN HALLUCINATION 51%

DISTILLATION CLOUD

THE CHIP HALF, ADVANCING

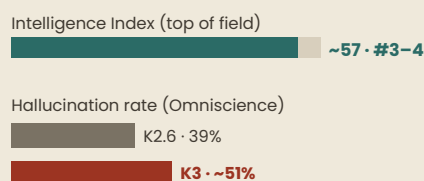
H200, relicensed and idle: a Commerce official told Congress on 14 July that shipments to China stay "trivial" despite ~US\$10b in approved licences; Beijing steers buyers to Huawei, whose Ascend 950PR is in mass production, claimed at 2.8× the H20's FP4.⁴

THE CHATTER

On r/LocalLLaMA and Hacker News the K3 threads split three ways: admiration for the coding results, irritation at the bespoke licence, and unease at the hallucination figure. The recurring line is the useful one — a benchmark-topping model you cannot trust to say "I don't know" is a different tool, and the gap matters most for agents left to run unattended.

— r/LocalLLaMA; Hacker News, 27–28 Jul 2026

K3: the number and the asterisk



A Meridian original. Source: Artificial Analysis Intelligence Index & Omniscience eval; hallucination absent from Moonshot's own charts.

Frontier-class on capability, and rising on the one metric its maker did not print.

THE SCEPTIC

Hold the benchmark loosely. Some analysts note K3's coding scores mix more than one agent-harness config; the hallucination figure is third-party and worth replication; and the distillation allegation is unproven — an accusation is not a finding. On the chips, take last week's "zero" as forward share, not installed base: over a million H20s already sit in China, and winning the next sale is not matching Nvidia's best silicon.⁴

SOURCES 1 Artificial Analysis, Jul 2026 (Kimi K3 #3-4 of 189 on the Intelligence Index at ~57 — "comparable to Opus 4.8 and GPT-5.5, behind Fable 5 and GPT-5.6 Sol"; nine providers day-0 at US\$3/\$15 per M tokens; ~\$0.94/Index task vs \$1.80 for Opus 4.8). 2 Artificial Analysis Omniscience eval, via Kili / digitalapplied (accuracy 33% → 46% K2.6 → K3; hallucination 39% → ~51%; absent from Moonshot's own charts). 3 propakistani, 18 Jul; MindStudio (OSTP official alleges Moonshot distilled Anthropic's Claude; K3 reportedly self-IDs as "Claude"; unproven, timing called implausible by independent researchers). 4 Tom's Hardware, 15 Jul (a Commerce official told Congress H200 shipments to China stay "trivial" despite ~US\$10b approved licences; ~75,000-chip customer caps; Beijing steers buyers to Huawei); TechTimes / CFR (Huawei Ascend 950PR in mass production, claimed 2.8× H20 FP4; B30A — half a B300, 144GB, timing unconfirmed; "zero" is forward share — 1M+ H20s already in China; share ≠ capability).

TECHNOLOGY · THE HOME LAB

The Open-Weight Retreat

Start with what the home lab cannot keep. Kimi K3's release weights run about 594 gigabytes in MXFP4 and roughly 1.56 terabytes at full precision across 96 shards, want a realistic floor of eight H100s, and — the practical killer — neither llama.cpp nor Ollama can load them, because K3's new Kimi Delta Attention has been upstreamed only to vLLM.¹ One enthusiast streamed the weights off an SSD on a 64GB Mac at sixteen seconds a token: proof it “runs,” and proof no one would use it that way. The frontier open model is, for a home rig, a spectator sport.

The quieter worry is that the *runnable* open frontier is thinning. Alibaba spent late July shipping Qwen models — a Max preview, new image and audio releases — all API-only, no weights; the last open general Qwen remains April's 27B.² As the Chinese labs close or leash their best work, the MIT-licensed holdout is DeepSeek V4: a Flash config at 284B/13B-active for a well-specced rig, a 1.6-trillion Pro for those with the silicon, topping 80 per cent on SWE-

bench.³ Alongside it GLM-5.2 and MiniMax M3 stay self-hostable, and a 128GB Strix Halo still runs a 30B all day. The home lab's frontier is no longer the biggest model — it is the biggest one still shipping weights under a licence you can live with.

594 GB

THE KIMI K3 RELEASE WEIGHTS IN MXFP4 (1.56TB FULL) — AND NO LLAMA.CPP OR OLLAMA RUNTIME TO LOAD THEM. OPEN, AND UNREACHABLE.

The home lab's frontier is the biggest model still shipping weights you can actually run.

~\$3,999

A 128GB STRIX HALO BOX IN SINGAPORE THIS WEEK (ONEXSTATION LAUNCH PROMO) — THE MACHINE THAT HOLDS A 30B-CLASS MODEL AND THE DAILY HOME-LAB LOAD.

QWEN GOES CLOSED

DEEPSEEK V4 · MIT

CAN'T-LOAD-K3

HOUSEKEEPING

Strix Halo, priced in SG: 128GB Ryzen AI Max+ 395 boxes now land around S\$3,999–4,199; the ProArt config runs higher.

RTX 5090: supply still tight, street around S\$4,329 — no clean sub-MSRP yet.

Meta Muse Spark 1.1: now a paid developer API at ~US\$1.25/\$4.25 per M — the closed counter-move.⁴

THE CHATTER

The r/LocalLLaMA mood this week was less awe than accounting. The thread that landed was about the retreat: a benchmark-topping K3 that no home runtime loads, a Qwen line going API-only, and a shrinking shortlist of models a serious rig can actually hold. DeepSeek staying MIT was the relief note — the community's read is that the open frontier is now defended by one lab more than led by many.

— r/LocalLLaMA home-lab threads, 27–29 Jul 2026

THE SCEPTIC

The “run it all locally” dream keeps its ceiling, and K3 is well above it — anyone claiming a home K3 is quietly running a badly degraded config, and should say so. Two sourcing cautions: DeepSeek V4's exact GA date is muddled (an April preview and a mid-July GA both circulate), so trust the config specs over the calendar; and the Strix Halo prices are launch-promo and reseller listings, not a settled street.

THE FRONTIER, RENTED

The models that topped the charts this week are all, one way or another, someone else's to run: K3 by supernode, Qwen's best by API, Meta's Muse Spark by the token. That is the shape of 2026 — the open weights worth downloading are the mid-sized ones. The home lab's job is to know where that line sits and keep its machine just below it.

SOURCES 1 Tom's Hardware; llama.cpp GH discussion #26041, 27 Jul (K3 release weights ~594GB MXFP4 / ~1.56TB full across 96 shards; realistic floor ~8×H100 80GB; Kimi Delta Attention upstreamed to vLLM only — no llama.cpp/Ollama support); explainx (HN anecdote: K3 streamed off SSD on a 64GB M1 Max at ~16 s/token — colour, not a benchmark). 2 digitalapplied; codersera (Alibaba shipped Qwen3.8-Max-Preview + image/audio, 19–21 Jul, API-only, no weights; last open general Qwen = April's 27B). 3 morphilm; DataCamp; HuggingFace (DeepSeek V4, MIT: V4-Flash 284B/13B-active ~160GB, V4-Pro 1.6T/49B-active, 1M ctx, top tier >80% SWE-bench Verified) — GA date muddled (Apr preview vs mid-Jul GA), flagged; GLM-5.2 (Z.ai, MIT) and MiniMax M3 remain self-hostable. 4 VideoCardz; Carousell SG (128GB Strix Halo boxes ~S\$3,999–4,199; RTX 5090 street ~S\$4,329); AI Weekly (Meta Muse Spark 1.1 paid API ~US\$1.25/\$4.25 per M).

THE KIT · WEARABLES

The Cheaper Sensor, and Whether You Can Train on It

Garmin's CIRQA — the \$200 screen-free band that undercuts Whoop's subscription — drew its first reviews this week, and they landed on one question: it carries an older heart-rate sensor than Garmin's own newer watches. For a reader who trains on the number, that is the whole review.

The band itself is settled — US\$199.99 since 24 July, screen-free, no subscription, a ten-day battery, and the recovery set Whoop charges monthly for: heart rate, Body Battery, HRV Status, stress, skin temperature, no GPS, no ECG.¹ The reviews argued over a component: CIRQA uses Garmin's older Elevate Gen 4 optical sensor, not the Gen 5 in its newer watches, and Garmin's reason — Gen 5 would have made the band thicker — did not convince everyone.

The5krunner called that “does not add up,” noting Garmin's own Index Sleep Monitor runs Gen 5 at 7.8mm while the CIRQA is nine — so the real drivers are cost and battery at the \$199 price, not physics.² DC Rainmaker was gentler: for everyday tracking he judged the Gen-4-to-Gen-5 gap negligible, its main loss being the ECG CIRQA omits anyway. The read

sits between them — a fine lifestyle band with a sensor good enough for trends and fair to doubt for anyone training on the raw number. The rest of the week's gear is on the shelf.

US\$199.99

THE CIRQA'S ONE-TIME PRICE AGAINST WHOOP'S SUBSCRIPTION — THE PITCH IS UNCHANGED; REVIEW WEEK MADE THE SENSOR, NOT THE PRICE, THE QUESTION.

A fine band at a one-time price — with a sensor good enough for trends, and fair to doubt for the number you train on.

REVIEWS IN

GEN-4 SENSOR

NO SUBSCRIPTION

THE CHATTER

On r/Garmin the sensor became the whole thread — the community welcomes an off-the-shelf answer to the monthly-fee question, then splits on whether an older optical module is a corner cut or a sensible trade for battery and price. The consensus lands close to DC Rainmaker: buy it for the no-fee tracking, not a leap in accuracy, and keep the chest strap for interval days.

— r/Garmin; the5krunner; DC Rainmaker, 27 Jul 2026

THE SCEPTIC

The honest caveat is sensing, not sums — and the reviews sharpened it rather than settled it. Optical HRV at the wrist has never matched a chest strap, and an older module leaning on Garmin's algorithms asks the software to cover the hardware. At US\$200 with no fee CIRQA is an easy lifestyle pick; whether its numbers are trustworthy enough to train on is the question a Gen-4 sensor now raises. And the shelf items stay held: a camera with no price and glasses with no number are announcements, not buys.

ON THE SHELF

Insta360 X6: broke cover this week — leaked specs show 8K/50fps and swappable Replaceable Lenses 2.0 — but as of Friday no official press release or price, only a retail-box leak.³

Samsung Galaxy Glasses: announced 22 Jul — display-free, Gemini-first, Gentle Monster/Warby Parker frames; ships this fall, price unstated.⁴

SOURCES 1 Garmin newsroom (“Meet CIRQA,” product refs 010-04675-00 to -03); DC Rainmaker, Jul 2026 (US\$199.99 from 24 Jul; screen-free, no subscription; ~10-day battery; 14.8g module, fabric loop; HR, Body Battery, HRV Status, Pulse Ox, stress, skin temp; no GPS/ECG; four colours). 2 the5krunner, 27 Jul (CIRQA uses Elevate Gen 4, not Gen 5; Garmin's “would make it thicker” reasoning “does not add up” — Index Sleep Monitor runs Gen 5 at 7.8mm vs CIRQA's 9mm; real drivers cost + battery); DC Rainmaker (Gen4-vs-Gen5 gap “negligible” for non-workout use; Gen 5's main add is ECG). 3 Gizmochina; Notebookcheck; GSMArena, 26–30 Jul (Insta360 X6 retail-box/FCC leaks — 8K/50fps, Replaceable Lenses 2.0, compact body; no official PR/price/date; battery/price figures disagree across leaks — imminent, not confirmed). 4 Samsung Global Newsroom; GSMArena, 22 Jul (Galaxy Glasses: display-free, Snapdragon ARI, Gemini-first, Gentle Monster/Warby Parker, ~50g, up to 9h; ships fall, price unstated).

THE CONNECTED HOME · HOME ASSISTANT

The Release That Kills the Port Number

The 2026.8 beta's changelog is now readable ahead of next week's release, and its most telling line is small: new installs drop the ":8123" from the address bar, and network settings move out of YAML into the interface — with a five-minute failsafe so you cannot lock yourself out. The "non-technical" Home Assistant, in concrete form.

Home Assistant 2026.8 branched on 22 July and goes stable around 5 August, and this week the release-candidate notes made the "approachability" slogan concrete.¹ Two changes carry the theme. New Home Assistant OS installs now serve on an ordinary web address — the famous ":8123" port drops off the URL — and the web-server port, network interface and trusted-proxy settings move out of YAML files into the interface, wrapped in a five-minute failsafe that automatically rolls back if you do not confirm the change, so a mistyped setting no longer locks you out of your own house.² Smaller touches follow: flexible entity naming, an entity filter that narrows by manufacturer and model, and automatable Moon-phase events.

For a local-first Lutron-to-HA household the on-brand addition is NeoPool, which talks to pool controllers over local Modbus TCP with no cloud in the path.³ The migrator's fine print holds from No. 57:

THE CHATTER

On the r/homeassistant beta thread the loudest approval was for exactly the small stuff — killing the port number and moving network config into the UI read to the regulars as proof the "non-technical" push is real this time, not a slogan. The tempering note is the usual one: it is onboarding polish, most of it for new installs, and a running box gains little it must have.

— r/homeassistant; HA community beta-week thread, Jul 2026

THE SCEPTIC

Two cautions. Most of 2026.8's marquee polish — the dropped port, the in-UI network settings — applies to *new* HA OS installs, so an established migrator's box sees onboarding niceties, not a reason to rush the upgrade. And the release's headline integrations (NeoPool, a vehicle tracker) are niche by design. Read it as the project lowering the on-ramp for the next household, not a must-install for the one already running — and wait for the final notes on 5 August before touching a working system, especially with the ESPHome re-join churn in the same window.

the companion app drops iOS 15, watchOS 8 and macOS 11. On the DIY side ESPHome's native-Zigbee build-out continues — its 2026.7 line moved to Zigbee SDK 2.0.2, so ESP32 devices must be re-joined after upgrading.⁴ Lutron had no news; *lutron_caseta* is unchanged. Matter's one line: doorbell button-presses now arrive as event entities.

5-min

THE FAILSAFE ON 2026.8'S NEW IN-UI NETWORK SETTINGS — CHANGE THE PORT OR INTERFACE AND IT AUTO-ROLLS-BACK UNLESS YOU CONFIRM. ANTI-LOCKOUT, BY DESIGN.

The most "non-technical" change in the release is the one that deletes a port number from the address bar.

HA 2026.8

NO MORE :8123

NEOPOOL LOCAL

IN BRIEF

Companion floors: iOS 15 / watchOS 8 / macOS 11 dropped from 2026.8.0.

ESPHome breaking: Zigbee SDK 2.0.2 changes storage layout — re-join ESP32 devices after upgrade.

Matter: doorbell presses now event entities — nothing else that changes a Lutron-plus-HA house.

SOURCES 1 rc.home-assistant.io, "2026.8 Beta: A betta title," 22 Jul (beta branched 22 Jul; stable ~5 Aug; release-party livestream 5 Aug 20:00 GMT; theme "something you don't need to be technical to use"). 2 rc.home-assistant.io; Matter Alpha (new HA OS installs serve without the :8123 port; web-server port / network interface / trusted-proxy config move into the UI with a 5-minute auto-rollback failsafe; flexible entity naming; entity filter by manufacturer/model; Moon integration event entities). 3 rc.home-assistant.io (NeoPool integration — pool controllers over local Modbus TCP, no cloud; ScorpionTrack vehicle location; HA Cloud settings redesigned; built-in backup for all install types); home-assistant.io/faq/release (companion app drops iOS 15 / watchOS 8 / macOS 11 from 2026.8.0). 4 ESPHome 2026.7.x changelog (Zigbee SDK bumped to 2.0.2 — storage layout change, ESP32 devices must re-join/reconfigure after upgrade; endpoint-merging default on; DIY Zigbee end-devices on ESP32/nRF52); Lutron press index (no delta; Caséta smart wood blinds, Feb 2026, the last PR). Matter doorbell button-press event entities per Matter Alpha.

THE GOOD LIFE · WATCHES

A Watch You Wear to Read the World

A Dubai atelier has taken Perrelet's travel GMT and hand-painted its dial into a compass rose ringed by the four corners of the globe — no two alike, fifty made, US\$2,990. A lovely, honest object, sold on paint and scarcity rather than horology. Read it as education, not endorsement.

IFL Watches, a Dubai maker known for hand-painted dials, put its reworked Perrelet Weekend GMT Atlas on sale on 27 July — a fifty-piece limited edition at US\$2,990.¹ The case is a compact 39 millimetres in steel; inside runs Perrelet's calibre P-401, a 25-jewel automatic beating at 28,800vph with a 42-hour reserve, carrying a GMT hand and date, on a steel bracelet with a quick-release blue leather strap. The reason to look is the dial. A central compass rose is ringed by four hand-painted scenes — a scarlet macaw over rainforest, palms on a shore, arctic peaks, pyramids in desert — so every one of the fifty is, literally, one of a kind.

For a reader who travels — Tokyo especially — a GMT with a painted map of the world is an easy thing to like, and the enthusiast press liked it: Fratello handled it as a “wear-the-world” collector piece, Deployant in the same warm register.² Read it as

education, not endorsement, and keep the year's real money in view — Phillips' first-half watch sales ran to about US\$507 million, up some sixty per cent on the spring of 2025, headlined by an F.P. Journe Souscription Résonance that made US\$13.9 million.³ The Atlas is not that. It is a small, characterful thing bought for its paint. This is context, not investment advice.

US\$2,990

THE WEEKEND GMT ATLAS — 50 PIECES, EACH WITH A ONE-OF-A-KIND HAND-PAINTED DIAL, ON A 39MM PERRELET GMT. THE VALUE IS THE ARTISTRY AND THE SCARCITY.

A GMT with a hand-painted map of the world — fifty made, and no two the same.

HAND-PAINTED

TRAVEL GMT

50 PIECES

US\$507m

PHILLIPS' H1-2026 WATCH SALES, +~60% ON SPRING 2025 — THE YEAR'S REAL MONEY, AND THE SCALE AGAINST WHICH A US\$2,990 PAINTED GMT IS A PLEASURE, NOT AN INVESTMENT.³

THE CHATTER

The reception is warm and narrow, as a fifty-piece collab's tends to be: the watch press admires the artistry-and-travel concept and the fact that no two dials match, while noting this is a wear-the-world curiosity, not a horological statement. Broad forum buzz is thin — a niche release for people who want a painting on the wrist rather than a spec to argue about.

— Fratello; Deployant; Review Central ME, 28 Jul 2026

THE SCEPTIC

Price the paint, not the pedigree. The P-401 is a Soprod-based movement dressed in “in-house” language, and roughly US\$3,000 for a 39mm steel GMT from a small brand is a premium bought with hand-painted artistry and fifty-piece scarcity, not horological depth. Perrelet's secondary-market liquidity is soft — resale interest on the enthusiast forums is tepid — so this is a watch to buy because a particular painted dial delights you, not because it will hold value. A one-of-fifty object is a pleasure with a resale asterisk. Not investment advice.

SOURCES ¹ Fratello, 28 Jul; Deployant; Review Central ME, 28 Jul 2026; IFL Watches product page (IFL Watches × Perrelet “Weekend GMT Atlas,” Ref. A1304/SI; on sale 27 Jul 2026; 50-piece limited edition; US\$2,990; 39mm steel case; Perrelet calibre P-401, 25 jewels, 28,800vph, 42h reserve, GMT + date; steel bracelet + quick-release blue leather strap; individually hand-painted compass-rose dial, four scenes, no two alike). ² Fratello hands-on; Deployant (enthusiast reception — “wear-the-world” collector piece; broad forum buzz thin for a 50-piece collab). ³ The Art Newspaper, 10 Jul (Phillips H1-2026 watch-led sales ~US\$507m, +~60% vs spring 2025, 90% sell-through; F.P. Journe Résonance “Souscription No. 007” made US\$13.9m in New York) — context/education; the P-401 is a Soprod-based movement; Perrelet secondary-market liquidity soft per WatchUSeek. Not investment advice.

SCREEN & SOUND · FILM

Every Number Is In but the One That Counts

Spider-Man: Brand New Day goes wide in America today, its verdict now firmed — Certified Fresh at ninety-one across a hundred and fifty-one reviews, and still the lowest of Tom Holland's four solos. The one figure the weekend has not yet printed is the money, and everyone is guessing at it.

The critical picture hardened this week. Brand New Day now sits at 91 per cent Certified Fresh across 151 reviews — up from the ~126 No. 57 carried — with a Metacritic around 70: the best-received Marvel film in a while, yet the weakest-reviewed of Holland's four solos, whose earlier three ran 91 to 93.¹ Praise clusters on the cast — Sadie Sink, Jon Bernthal's returning Punisher — and several critics call it the best-directed Spider-Man since Raimi. It opened in Singapore on 30 July; the US wide release is today.

The one number still missing is the money, and here the honest desk holds the line: as of Friday no actual grosses and no CinemaScore have been published — the figures circulating are Sony's own projection and an early, small audience sample, not results.² What is real is the anticipation: Fandango's biggest pre-seller of 2026, its strongest pre-sales since No Way Home, with tracking spread wide — Sony near US\$195m,

analysts US\$230–250m, bulls past US\$270m, a worldwide opening around US\$425–465m. Read them as odds; the weekend prints the fact. A correction to No. 57 on the audio side: New Music Friday on 1 August is thin, the Hackett-Rothery record lands on 28 August, not this week, and Morgan Wallen dropped a surprise single, “Been By Now.”⁴

91%

BRAND NEW DAY'S TOMATOMETER ACROSS 151 REVIEWS — CERTIFIED FRESH, UP FROM ~126 LAST WEEK, AND STILL THE LOWEST OF HOLLAND'S FOUR SOLO SCORES.

The score is printed and the ticket is torn. The gross is still a rumour dressed as a number.

CERTIFIED FRESH

OPENS WIDE TODAY

GROSS STILL PENDING

\$180–300m

THE SPREAD OF DOMESTIC-OPENING PROJECTIONS — SONY ~\$195M, ANALYSTS TO \$250M, BULLS PAST \$270M. A PROJECTION IS NOT A GROSS; THE WEEKEND SETTLES IT.

THE CHATTER

On the fan threads the early mood skews enthusiastic on the “street-level, back-to-basics” pivot after years of world-ending stakes. The dissent is narrow: a minority find Bernthal's Punisher too grim for a Spider-Man film. It is the rare Marvel opening where fan mood and critic score point the same way — up, with one asterisk.³

— fan first-reactions coverage, 29–30 Jul 2026

THE SCEPTIC

Not everyone is charmed: IndieWire's David Ehrlich filed it as “a dull and downbeat” sequel that “wastes its chance for a fresh start,” and Variety judged it “a ‘mature’ adventure trying too hard” — the overstuffed-plot, table-setting knocks that keep the Metacritic at 70, Holland's lowest. And beware the numbers already circulating as fact: a “\$195m opening” is Sony's projection, and any “A” CinemaScore is unverifiable until the studio reports over the weekend. A record pre-sale measures anticipation, not the final gross. Read the ninety-one and the projections as odds, then go and see the film.

SOURCES 1 World of Reel, 28 Jul; RT editorial; Metacritic (Brand New Day 91% Certified Fresh across 151 reviews, MC ~70, lowest of Holland's four solos vs 91–93; cast praise for Sadie Sink and Jon Bernthal; dir. Destin Daniel Cretton; SG opened 30 Jul, US wide 31 Jul). 2 Deadline, 29 Jul; BroadwayWorld; ScreenRant (Fandango's biggest pre-seller of 2026, beating The Odyssey; strongest pre-sales since No Way Home; projections — Sony ~\$195m, analysts \$230–250m, bulls ~\$274–300m, worldwide ~\$425–465m; NO actual grosses or CinemaScore published as of Fri SG time; a circulating “\$195m/A” = projection + unverifiable). 3 Hollywood Reporter first-reactions coverage (fan enthusiasm for the street-level pivot; minority “Punisher too grim” gripe). 4 IndieWire (David Ehrlich, “dull and downbeat”); Variety (“trying too hard”); loudersound; RollingStone (New Music Fri 1 Aug thin; Hackett-Rothery “The Roaring Waves” 28 Aug — correcting No. 57; Ann Wilson & Tripsitter 14 Aug; Morgan Wallen single “Been By Now”; Thom Yorke solo LP loosely “later 2026,” single-sourced).

THE FAMILY DESK • SCREENS & POLICY

A Line Drawn, and the Fight Over Enforcing It

France's under-15 social-media ban is law — but lawmakers stripped out its enforcement mechanism, and the real fight has moved to Australia, where Elon Musk's X is challenging the crackdown. Meanwhile a large new study says the harm the bans assume is still not proven.

The delta on No. 57's France story is that the law arrived with its teeth removed. In the final horse-trading around the 21 July vote, lawmakers stripped out the age-verification enforcement mechanism, leaving the EU's Digital Services Act as the only real tool — and the rollout is two-phase: no new under-15 accounts from September, existing users until 1 January 2027 to verify age.¹ The Constitutional Council is expected to review the law first. So the “first EU ban” is real as a statement and unfinished as a machine.

Where enforcement is actually being tested is Australia, whose world-first under-16 ban has already deactivated some 4.7 million accounts — and where, on 28 July, Elon Musk's X publicly accused the government of over-reaching, the ban's first real platform-versus-regulator flashpoint.² Public opinion runs ahead of the evidence: a July Pew poll found 56

per cent of US adults now support a ban for everyone under sixteen.³ None of these laws binds an eleven-year-old yet — but the norm they set, and the enforcement fights they are starting, are the weather the next few years will be lived in. General guidance, not medical advice.

4.7m

ACCOUNTS AUSTRALIA SAYS ITS UNDER-16 BAN HAS CLOSED — AND THE NUMBER NOW AT THE CENTRE OF A PUBLIC FIGHT WITH MUSK'S X OVER HOW FAR A REGULATOR CAN REACH.

The first EU ban is real as a statement and unfinished as a machine. The enforcement is being fought elsewhere.

TEETH STRIPPED

AUSTRALIA VS X

PEW 56%

THE FINE PRINT

France, phased: new under-15 accounts blocked from Sept; existing users must verify age by 1 Jan 2027; Constitutional Council review pending.

The counter-counterweight: Melbourne's MCRI still finds >2h/day linked to small later rises in depressive symptoms — modest, not zero.

THE CHATTER — DON'T BE ALARMIST

The counterweight is no longer just an opinion. University of Manchester researchers followed more than 25,000 pupils aged eleven to fourteen across three school years and found no evidence that more social-media or gaming time leads to more anxiety or depression — a hint, even, that the relationship runs the other way.⁴ A large longitudinal study is a heavier object than a headline.

— University of Manchester (#BeeWell), Journal of Public Health, Jan 2026

THE SCEPTIC

A ban is a signal, not a switch — and a ban without its enforcement mechanism is barely even the signal. The psychologist Candice Odgers argues the claim that these platforms are “rewiring our children's brains and causing an epidemic” is not supported by the science, and may distract from the real causes of youth distress. Hold both honestly: delaying a young child's entry is a reasonable, cheap default, while the certainty in the legislation outruns the evidence under it. General guidance, not medical advice.⁴

SOURCES 1 CNN, 21 Jul; NPR, 22 Jul; TechTimes; Connexion France, Jul 2026 (France passed the under-15 social-media ban 21 Jul but stripped the age-verification enforcement mechanism, leaving the DSA as the enforcement tool; new under-15 accounts blocked from Sept 2026; existing users must verify age by 1 Jan 2027; Constitutional Council review expected before it starts). 2 Al Jazeera, 16 Jan; US News/Reuters, 28 Jul 2026 (Australia's under-16 ban deactivated ~4.7m accounts by mid-Jan; Musk's X publicly accuses Australia of over-reach/undermining international law). 3 Reason, 6 Jul 2026 (Pew: 56% of US adults support a social-media ban for everyone under 16). 4 University of Manchester (#BeeWell); Journal of Public Health, Jan 2026 (>25,000 pupils 11–14 over three years; no evidence more social-media/gaming time raises anxiety or depression; possible reverse direction); NPR, 26 Jun 2026 (Candice Odgers: harm case not supported, may distract from real causes); MCRI, 11 Jun (>2h/day linked to small later rises in depressive symptoms — counter-counterweight). General guidance, not medical advice.

THE FAMILY DESK • THE TWEEN YEARS

The Hormone, Not the Look, Is What Tracks

The most useful study of the week for a household with a preteen daughter came out of the University of Georgia. Researchers analysed more than 5,400 girls in the US Adolescent Brain Cognitive Development cohort and found that in girls aged ten to twelve it was rising testosterone — not estradiol, and not how visibly developed a girl looked — that was the strongest hormonal predictor of anxiety and depression symptoms, even after accounting for other hormones.¹ The finding reframes a common assumption: the internal chemistry of early puberty, not its outward signs, is what tracks with early distress — and it points at a window, ages ten to twelve, to put support in place before difficulties settle in.

Keep the caveat in plain sight: this is correlational. It shows hormone change moving together with distress, not testosterone “causing” it, and it cannot tell any individual parent what their own child will feel.² Set beside No. 57’s puberty-timing findings, the through-line is steady — the biology of these years deserves attention, not alarm — and the lever with evidence behind it stays the same one: “add a good thing.” Sleep, movement, unstructured time and a

meal together are the interventions that hold, and the ones that outperform simply subtracting a screen. Friendship matters too, in a way a second study this week made concrete. General guidance, not medical advice.

5,400+

GIRLS IN THE ABCD COHORT WHERE RISING TESTOSTERONE — NOT ESTRADIOL, NOT VISIBLE DEVELOPMENT — WAS THE STRONGEST HORMONAL PREDICTOR OF ANXIETY AND DEPRESSION AT AGES 10–12.

It is the internal chemistry of early puberty, not its outward signs, that tracks with a preteen girl’s distress.

10–12

THE WINDOW THE RESEARCHERS FLAG — EARLY ENOUGH TO PUT EMOTIONAL SUPPORT IN PLACE BEFORE DIFFICULTIES ENTRENCH. GENERAL GUIDANCE, NOT MEDICAL ADVICE.

TESTOSTERONE, NOT THE LOOK

AGES 10–12

ADD, DON’T ONLY SUBTRACT

THE CHATTER — WHO THEIR FRIENDS ARE

A second 2026 study makes the friendship point measurable: a Finnish cohort of more than 600,000 found adolescents whose school peers had psychiatric diagnoses — or a predisposition to them — carried a modestly higher subsequent risk of their own. Read carefully, it is not “bad friends cause illness” but that mental health travels through peer networks — a reason to know who a tween spends time with, not to police it.

— JAMA Psychiatry; [phys.org](https://www.phys.org), Jul 2026

FOR A HOUSEHOLD WITH AN 11-YEAR-OLD

The window: ten to twelve — put emotional support in place before, not after.

The lever that holds: sleep, sport, in-person time and a shared meal beat a bare ban.

The caveat: both studies are correlational — act on the reasonable case, not a certain one.

THE SCEPTIC — DON’T BE ALARMIST

Resist the leap from a hormone to a headline. This is an association in a large cohort, not a test any parent should ask a paediatrician to run — there is no clinical action item in “testosterone tracks with distress,” and treating a normal biological process as a warning light would do more harm than the finding warrants. The peer-network study carries the same asterisk. The honest takeaway is unglamorous: the early-teen years deserve steady attention, the interventions that work are the boring ones, and a correlation is a reason to be present, not to be afraid. General guidance, not medical advice.

SOURCES ¹UGA News; MedicalXpress; Neuroscience News; PsyPost, Jul 2026 (University of Georgia, lead Assaf Oshri; >5,400 girls in the ABCD study; in girls 10–12, rising testosterone — not estradiol, not visible physical development — the strongest hormonal predictor of anxiety/depression symptoms, after accounting for DHEA and estradiol; ages 10–12 a window for support; published Psychoneuroendocrinology). ² Evidence caveat: correlational/observational — hormone change tracks with distress, not shown to cause it; cannot predict an individual child. JAMA Psychiatry, 2026 (Alho, Gutvilig, Niemi et al.; 604,819 Finns; peers’ psychiatric diagnoses / genetic predisposition modestly raise an adolescent’s subsequent risk, strongest in high-school years — “social transmission”); [phys.org](https://www.phys.org), Jul 2026 (plain-English + caveats). Add-don’t-only-subtract lever and COMPASS girls-languishing carried from Nos. 55–57. General guidance, not medical advice.

THE MACRO DESK · THE PORTFOLIO LENS

The Dollar Was Supposed to Rise. It Fell.

The Bank of Japan held but leaned hawkish, Amazon's cloud blew past every estimate, and gold pushed toward \$4,100 on the Gulf. And yet the dollar, the one thing a rate-and-war story is meant to lift, slipped a full per cent. The clean signal this week is not the Fed — it is the AI cloud pulling the tape apart.

VWRA ~\$185	AGGU ~\$5.80	US 10Y ~4.65%	USD/JPY ~163.6	DXY ▼ ~99.9	BRENT ~\$90	GOLD ▲ ~\$4,100	BTC ▲ ~\$64.5k
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Start with the resolutions. The Bank of Japan held its rate at 1.00 per cent on 31 July, as expected, but leaned hawkish — nudging its 2026 growth forecast up to about 0.8 per cent from 0.5, with economists in a Reuters poll putting the odds of a move to 1.25 per cent by year-end at 86, October the favoured month.¹ The yen stayed near a forty-year low around 163.6 to the dollar. On the corporate tape the dispersion was the story: Amazon's AWS grew 37 per cent — its fastest since 2021, well past the ~31 expected — and the shares jumped eight to nine per cent after hours, while Apple beat on revenue and profit yet fell about 2.4 per cent because its Services line missed.² The reward went to visible AI monetisation; the punishment to anything that looked like a slowdown.

Now the oddity. This should have been a dollar-up week — a hawkish Fed hold behind it (No. 57), a hawkish BoJ, a Gulf war widening (p3), gold bid toward \$4,100 as a haven. Instead the dollar index

slipped about a per cent to near 99.9, down from the ~101.6 it held last week.³ A softening dollar alongside firm long yields and a gold bid is not a classic risk-off; it says the market's dominant force this week was not the rate path or the war but the AI-capex cycle sorting winners from laggards. The Fed did not move the tape. The cloud did.

+37%

AMAZON'S AWS GROWTH, ITS FASTEST SINCE 2021 — THE NUMBER THAT MOVED MARKETS MORE THAN ANY CENTRAL BANK THIS WEEK, AND SENT THE SHARES UP 8–9% AFTER HOURS.

A hawkish Fed, a hawkish BoJ, a widening war — and the dollar fell. The tape was listening to the cloud.

HIGHER-FOR-LONGER

DOLLAR EASES

AI-CLOUD DISPERSION

WHAT IT MEANS — VWRA, GLOBAL BONDS, GOLD & BTC

VWRA (held): the index masks a widening split — the cloud leaders (AWS, Azure) carry it while the laggards (Apple services, Meta) drag; the diversification is inside the tape, not just across it. **Global bonds (held):** long yields stay high, so duration is still the sore spot; a softer dollar is a mild relief for a USD-hedged AGGU holder but the level, not the currency, is the point. **Gold (read only):** bid toward US\$4,100 on the Gulf and an easing dollar, still well below its January peak. **BTC (read only):** firm near US\$64.5k but on thin ETF flows — high-beta risk, not a haven. The two he holds stay VWRA and global bonds; the two he only reads stay gold and BTC.³

THE SCEPTIC

Read the week honestly and half its headlines dissolve. The “oil premium is back” — yet Brent round-tripped its spike within a session (p3); the “dollar bid” — yet the dollar fell. What is actually confirmed is narrower: higher-for-longer rates, a hawkish BoJ inching up, and an AI-capex cycle that is now the market's main organising force. Gold at \$4,100 is doing hedging work that equities and the dollar are not yet corroborating. Market explanation, not investment advice; gold and bitcoin are read for macro sensitivity only, and bitcoin stays far more volatile than either anchor.³

SOURCES 1 TechTimes; Investing; ING, 27–31 Jul 2026 (BoJ held at 1.00% on 31 Jul; FY2026 GDP forecast nudged to ~0.8% from 0.5%; Reuters poll — 86% expect 1.25% by year-end, Oct favoured; yen near a ~40-year low, USD/JPY ~163.6). 2 StockStory; CNBC (Amazon Q2 revenue US\$200.6b, AWS US\$42.2b, +37% YoY — fastest since 2021, vs ~31% expected; shares +8–9% AH); MacRumors; AppleInsider (Apple FQ3 revenue US\$109.4b +16%, EPS US\$2.02, gross margin 50.1%; Services US\$30.74b missed est. US\$31.22b; shares ~2.4% AH). 3 Market strip — indicative levels around the 30 Jul US close / 31 Jul Asia: Bitcoin.com; Trading Economics (DXY ~99.3–99.9, ~-0.86% on 30 Jul, down from ~101.6 in No. 57); Yahoo Finance; Forbes (gold ~\$4,080–4,130, crested \$4,100 post-FOMC, still well below the late-Jan peak); CoinGecko (BTC ~\$64.5–64.8k, thin July ETF flows); Fed H.15 (10Y ~4.65%; 30Y ~5.20% held); Trading Economics (Brent ~\$90, WTI ~\$84; USD/SGD ~1.288). VWRA/AGGU exact NAVs held; indicative. Not investment advice; gold and bitcoin read for macro sensitivity only, not endorsed.

CURIOSITIES · ASTROPHYSICS

A Wind Three Hundred Thousand Light-Years Wide

Japan's XRISM X-ray satellite measured the wind off a distant quasar's black hole and found it carrying a hundred times the energy anyone had estimated — enough to stir gas across three hundred thousand light-years, far beyond the galaxy that hosts it.

A team led by Yohei Yamada of Tohoku University, using the Japanese-led XRISM X-ray satellite, turned it on the quasar H1821+643 — a supermassive black hole feeding some 3.4 billion light-years away in Draco — and measured the wind streaming off it.¹ The number is the story: the outflow carries roughly a hundred times more energy than earlier estimates — several billion supernovae — and stirs gas across about three hundred thousand light-years, well past the host galaxy. Published in *Nature Astronomy* on 28 July, it is a direct look at how one black hole regulates the growth of everything around it — the “feedback” astronomers had inferred but rarely weighed.

The retellable part is the scale: one object, at the centre of one galaxy, blowing a wind wider than the galaxy itself — a measurement only a new instrument makes, XRISM reading gas velocity from the exact

energies of its X-rays.² Meanwhile, look up — but not this week. Skip the Delta Aquariids, washed out by a near-full Moon on 30–31 July, and mark the night of 12–13 August: the Perseids peak on a near-new Moon, the darkest conditions in years, not to recur on the 12th until 2045.³

300,000

LIGHT-YEARS — THE REACH OF THE WIND OFF QUASAR H1821+643, MEASURED BY XRISM, CARRYING ~100× THE ENERGY PREVIOUSLY ESTIMATED. WIDER THAN THE GALAXY THAT HOSTS THE BLACK HOLE.

One black hole, at the centre of one galaxy, blowing a wind wider than the galaxy itself.

XRISM

100× THE ENERGY

PERSEIDS 12–13 AUG

LOOK UP — THE WINDOW

Skip: Delta Aquariids, 30–31 Jul, near-full Moon.

Mark: Perseids, night of 12–13 Aug, near-new Moon — best conditions in years.³

Honest rate: NASA's “~100/hr” is best-case dark-sky; meteor watchers flag 2026 may run ~50–75/hr.

THE CHATTER — THE OTHER ODD ONE

Off Mexico's Gulf of California, biologists filmed orcas doing something never described before: one grips a dead sharp-tail sunfish by the fin while a second charges it at speed, blasting the carcass into pieces the juveniles then eat — a tactic a co-author says demands “acute spatial awareness, acoustic communication and a shared understanding of physics.” Two filmed encounters only, function unproven, but a genuinely new page in orca behaviour.

— *Frontiers in Ethology*; CNN; *Smithsonian*, ~23 Jul 2026

THE SCEPTIC

Temper both. The XRISM result is a single quasar seen in one pointing, and the “hundred times” is a revision of a hard-to-measure turbulence-energy estimate, model-dependent, not to be generalised to every supermassive black hole without more targets. On the sky, the headline rate is a dark-sky ceiling — the American Meteor Society cautions 2026 may under-deliver at 50 to 75 an hour — and from near Singapore's light dome the shower rewards a dark-sky trip, not a balcony.

SOURCES ¹Tohoku University press release; EurekAlert; phys.org, 28 Jul 2026 (Yohei Yamada et al., Tohoku/Kanazawa/Tokyo Metropolitan Universities, using JAXA-led XRISM; quasar H1821+643 in Draco, ~3.4 billion light-years; wind carries ~100× more energy than previously estimated — equivalent to several billion supernovae — stirring gas across ~300,000 light-years, beyond the host galaxy; *Nature Astronomy*, 28 Jul). ²BBC Sky at Night; EurekAlert (XRISM microcalorimeter reads gas velocity from precise X-ray energies — precision earlier satellites lacked). ³Weather.com; NASA Night Sky Network; American Meteor Society (Perseids peak night 12–13 Aug 2026, near-new Moon, best conditions in years; NASA's “~100/hr” is best-case dark-sky; AMS/IMO caution 2026 may run ~50–75/hr, richer 2027; Delta Aquariids 30–31 Jul washed out by a near-full Moon). Orcas: *Frontiers in Ethology*; CNN; *Smithsonian Magazine*; *ScienceDaily*, ~23 Jul (Gulf of California “ram to fragment” on a sharp-tail sunfish; two filmed encounters, function inferred not established).

LOVE & LIFE · THE EXAMINED LIFE

The Deal-Breaker Is a Way of Life, Not a Ballot

A new experiment finds young Americans reject a date across party lines far more than they reward one within them — and the reason isn't "bad character." It's the lifestyle, the values it implies, and the fear of what family and friends will say.

Researchers at the University of Cologne — Shannon Taflinger and Ansgar Hudde, in the European Sociological Review — ran an online dating experiment with 1,097 US partisans aged twenty to thirty-three, and found the penalty asymmetric: people reject opposite-party profiles far more strongly than they reward same-party ones.¹ The driver was not a blanket judgment of the other side's character. It was an inference about values and everyday lifestyle — and anticipated disapproval from family and friends. Politics is read as a proxy for how a person lives and who would accept the pairing, not as a mark against the person.

The sharpest finding is who does the rejecting. Democratic women were the strongest rejecters — roughly twice as strongly as Democratic men, per the Cologne team.² (An aggregator's "four times" is inconsistent with the official summary; trust the

two-times figure.) Read as an examined-life note, it says the modern dating filter has quietly become a lifestyle filter wearing a political label — the objection is less "I disagree with you" than "I could not live how you live, and my people would notice."

1,097

US PARTISANS AGED 20–33 IN THE EXPERIMENT — WHO PENALISED A CROSS-PARTY PROFILE FAR MORE THAN THEY REWARDED A SAME-PARTY ONE, ON INFERRED LIFESTYLE, NOT CHARACTER.

The objection is less "I disagree with you" than "I could not live how you live — and my people would notice."

LIFESTYLE, NOT CHARACTER

ASYMMETRIC PENALTY

US 20–33

~2×

HOW MUCH MORE STRONGLY DEMOCRATIC WOMEN REJECTED CROSS-PARTY PROFILES THAN DEMOCRATIC MEN — THE STRONGEST EFFECT IN THE STUDY. (IGNORE THE AGGREGATOR'S "4×".)

THE CHATTER

The stated filter and the lived reality diverge. Pew found in 2020 that roughly seven in ten relationship-seeking Democrats wouldn't date a Trump voter — yet a 2026 dating-industry survey reports about forty per cent of singles have dated across party lines and would again. The profile is where the tribe speaks; the second date is where the individual does.³

— Pew Research (2020); datingnews.com survey, 2026

THE SCEPTIC

Hold it loosely. The sample is WEIRD and narrow — US only, ages twenty to thirty-three, not a mid-forties reader's world — and stated preferences on a rating task routinely overstate what people do when a real person is across the table. It is a hypothetical profile experiment, not observed dating: it measures the filter people announce, not the choices they make. And the effect is a tilt, not a wall — the forty-per-cent-dated-across-lines figure in the chatter box quietly confirms it. General guidance, an association study read with care.⁴

SOURCES 1 European Sociological Review (Oxford), 2026 (Taflinger & Hudde, University of Cologne, "Why do young US Americans avoid cross-partisan dating?"; online dating experiment, N=1,097 US partisans/leaners aged 20–33; opposite-party profiles rejected far more strongly than same-party rewarded; driver = inferred values/lifestyle mismatch + anticipated family/friend disapproval, not blanket character judgment); PsyPost, ~14 Jul. 2 University of Cologne press release; EurekAlert; The Star (Malaysia), 14 Jul (Democratic women the strongest rejecters, ~2× Democratic men; a circulating "~4×" figure is single-sourced and inconsistent with the official line — use ~2×). 3 Pew Research, 2020 (~71% of relationship-seeking Democrats wouldn't date a Trump voter); datingnews.com survey, 2026 (~40% have dated across party lines and would again). 4 Meridian methodological note: the study's sample is WEIRD/US-only/ages 20–33; it is a hypothetical profile-rating experiment, not observed dating, so stated preferences overstate behaviour, and the effect is a tilt rather than a wall. General guidance.

FITNESS · THE LONG GAME

Now We Can See the Repair Crew at Work

A new proteomics study took muscle biopsies before and after a hard lifting session and watched what happens next: the heavy load damages the contractile proteins, and a repair network tags the damage for clearance while building fresh protein to replace it. It is the machinery behind “use it or lose it,” finally photographed.

Researchers from the Universities of Hildesheim, Bonn and Freiburg, publishing in *Nature Communications*, took muscle biopsies from volunteers before and after a single bout of high-intensity resistance exercise — and again across periods of detraining and retraining.¹ The mechanism they mapped is tidy. Heavy lifting damages the myofibrillar proteins that do the contracting; that damage triggers a quality-control network which tags the broken proteins and clears them through autophagy, while simultaneously ramping up synthesis of new contractile protein to take their place. Damage, clear, rebuild — the loop that keeps a muscle strong, now traced at the level of the proteins themselves.

For a mid-forties reader the appeal is that it explains why progressive resistance training, specifically, holds off the muscle loss of ageing: the controlled damage is the signal that summons the repair crew.² But keep the caveat in full view. This is a small biopsy study with cellular endpoints — it explains a

mechanism; it does not measure strength, function or lifespan, and it prescribes no dose. The leap from “autophagy tidies damaged proteins” to “lift for longevity” is one the paper does not make. Set it beside No. 57’s strength sweet-spot — ninety to one hundred and twenty minutes a week — as the “why” under the “how much.” General guidance, not medical advice.

damage → rebuild

THE LOOP THE BIOPSIES CAUGHT: HEAVY LIFTING BREAKS CONTRACTILE PROTEINS, AUTOPHAGY CLEARS THEM, AND SYNTHESIS REPLACES THEM — THE CELLULAR BASIS OF “USE IT OR LOSE IT.”

The controlled damage of a hard lift is not the cost of training. It is the signal that summons the repair.

MUSCLE PROTEOMICS

MECHANISM, NOT DOSE

RESISTANCE TRAINING

THE CHATTER — THE LONGEVITY FEEDS

The longevity feeds circle the same consensus — strength plus Zone-2 plus some top-end cardio — and a commonly-cited meta-analysis of ~80,000 adults finding roughly 40 per cent lower early-death risk for doing both strength and cardio versus neither. The undercurrent worth heeding: influencers take VO2max as a number to “optimise” too literally, when a high-VO2max lifestyle tracks with longevity, not the wrist figure itself.³

— longevity discourse; meta-analysis summaries, 2026

THE SCEPTIC

Resist the mechanism-to-mandate leap. A molecular study in healthy volunteers is a beautiful photograph of a process, not a prescription — it cannot tell a comfortable mid-forties reader how much to lift, how often, or whether it will add a year. And the Zone-2-versus-intensity debate stays live: recent reviews find matched-volume higher-intensity work equals or beats Zone-2 for VO2max, and is more time-efficient under about six hours a week — so there is no single optimal protocol to buy into. Protect the strength because the broad association is robust, not because this cohort proved anything about you. Not medical advice.⁴

SOURCES | *Nature Communications*, 2026 (“Fractionated proteomics identifies a protein network mitigating resistance exercise-induced damage in human skeletal muscle”; Universities of Hildesheim, Bonn, Freiburg; ~28 Jul; muscle biopsies before/after a single high-intensity resistance bout + across detraining/retraining; heavy lifting damages myofibrillar proteins → a repair network tags and clears them via autophagy while promoting synthesis of new contractile protein); University of Freiburg / University of Bonn (news 149-2026) press releases; news-medical.net; medicalxpress, 28 Jul. 2 Context: BJSM, 11 Jun 2026 (strength sweet spot ~90–120 min/wk, ~13% lower premature-death risk, n=147,000/30 yr — No. 57). 3 Longevity chatter: commonly-cited meta-analysis (~80,000 adults, ~40% lower early-death risk for strength + cardio vs neither); the VO2max-as-a-number-to-optimise critique (a high-VO2max lifestyle tracks with longevity, not the wrist figure itself). 4 Sceptic: this is a small biopsy study with cellular endpoints — no strength, function, mortality outcome or dose; *Sports Medicine* / Zone-2-vs-HIIT reviews (matched-volume higher intensity equals or beats Zone-2 for VO2max, more time-efficient under ~6h/wk), so no single optimal protocol. Not medical advice.

THE DIARY • SINGAPORE

The Week the Alarms Go Off

Two of the autumn's biggest on-sales land in the same August week — sumo tickets on the 8th, BIGBANG's presale on the 11th — and MAMAMOO plays tonight. Set the alarms; the good seats do not wait.

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW • PLAN AHEAD

- 31 JUL** **MAMAMOO '4WARD'** — Singapore Indoor Stadium, tonight, 7.30pm. The K-pop night the calendar catches just as it closes.¹
- 4–6 Aug** **HONNE — 10-Year Anniversary** — Capitol Theatre, three nights. The genuine near-term on-sale for the reflective end of the calendar.²
- 25 SEP** **Post Malone** — National Stadium, 'BIG ASS Stadium World Tour'; Don Toliver supporting (a delta on last week — the guest is now named).³
- 9–11 Oct** **Singapore Grand Prix** — the first-ever Singapore Sprint; bill deep — **The Killers** (Sat), **Lana Del Rey** (Sun, SG debut), plus Janet Jackson, JJ Lin, Zara Larsson and Goo Goo Dolls.⁴
- 17 OCT** **BIGBANG 'XX: Cosmos'** — National Stadium, first SG show in 11 years, one night. VIP presale 11 Aug, general 13 Aug; from S\$158.⁵
- 17–22 Dec** **BTS World Tour 'ARIRANG'** — National Stadium, four nights (17/19/20/22 Dec). **Sold out**; face-value resale only, scam advisory stands.⁶

JAPAN & THE REGION

TOKYO-FOCUSED • THE AUTUMN CALENDAR

- 13–27 Sep** **Grand Sumo Aki Basho** — Ryōgoku Kokugikan, Tokyo. Official advance tickets open **8 Aug**; weekend and final-day seats vanish within hours. Arena from ~¥5,000.⁶
- to 8 Oct** **teamLab Borderless** — Azabudai Hills. The "Light Sculpture — Flow" room reopened 8 Jul with two new series, showing until 8 Oct. Family-friendly; the museum runs on.⁷
- 9–10 Oct** **Takayama Autumn Festival** — Gifu. Eleven ornate floats; the 9 Oct evening yomatsuri is the highlight. It clashes with the Grand Prix weekend, left — you cannot do both.⁷
- 3 NOV** **Lexus Melbourne Cup** — Flemington. Public tickets not yet on sale — register interest via the VRC; travel packages bookable now.⁸

THE SCEPTIC — BOOK WITH CARE

The standing rule holds: a dated event is only as bookable as its primary source, and everything above is checked against Live Nation Singapore, the Kallang or the promoters. The BTS nights are sold out and a fraud magnet — treat any "spare pair" above face value as a scam. And ginkgo peak dates shift with the weather: "late November" is a window to plan around, not a date to fly for.

SOURCES 1 Time Out SG; Songkick (MAMAMOO '4WARD', Indoor Stadium, 31 Jul, 7.30pm); Malay Mail / Time Out, Jul 2026 (Jam Hsiao 'Wild/Mild', Indoor Stadium, 25 Oct, general sale 30 Jul, from S\$168). 2 Songkick; en.tempco.co (HONNE 10-Year Anniversary, Capitol Theatre, 4–6 Aug, three nights). 3 Live Nation SG; Songkick (Post Malone, National Stadium, 25 Sep; special guest Don Toliver — named this week). 4 Honeycombers; FZINE; Urban List SG (Singapore GP 9–11 Oct, first Singapore Sprint; The Killers 10 Oct, Lana Del Rey 11 Oct SG debut, Janet Jackson, JJ Lin, Zara Larsson, James Arthur, Goo Goo Dolls). 5 MustShareNews; Ticketmaster SG (BIGBANG 'XX: Cosmos', National Stadium, 17 Oct, VIP presale 11 Aug, general 13 Aug, from S\$158); Singapore Tourism Board; Live Nation SG (BTS 'ARIRANG', 17/19/20/22 Dec, sold out; face S\$148–S\$388; CASE/Police scam advisory). 6 Tokyo Cheapo; BuySumoTickets (Aki Basho, Ryōgoku Kokugikan, 13–27 Sep; official advance tickets 8 Aug; arena ~¥5,000–10,000, box from ~¥40,000). 7 teamlab.art; Tokyo Cheapo (teamLab Borderless, Azabudai Hills — "Light Sculpture — Flow" reopened 8 Jul, two new series, to 8 Oct); Japan Cheapo; Japan Travel (Takayama Autumn Festival, 9–10 Oct, fixed dates — clashes with the FI weekend). 8 Tokyo Cheapo; Japan Travel (Meiji Jingū Gaien ginkgo peak late Nov, weather-dependent; illuminations ~23–30 Nov per one source); National Today; Austadiums (Lexus Melbourne Cup, Tue 3 Nov, Flemington; register interest via the VRC).

THE TABLE • SINGAPORE'S NEWEST OPENINGS

Four Tables, and One Window That Closes in September

A Ginza sushi master is at his Singapore counter only until September, a three-Michelin group finishes its lobster in fried rice, a Seongsu-style café for the weekend, and a viral Chinese dessert chain's first outpost — one clear book-now, the rest a mix of proven and too-new.

The timely one is **Ginza Sushi Arai**, the first overseas outpost of Tokyo's acclaimed edomae house, at Parkroyal Collection Marina Bay — eight counter seats and a six-seat room, seafood flown daily from Toyosu, chef Junpeng Wang at the counter under founder Hiroyuki Arai's direction. The book-now hook: master Arai is *personally* at the Singapore counter from July to September each year — that is, right now. One seating nightly (6.30pm), Tuesday to Sunday, S\$398++. It opened in February, so it is not a fresh launch — but the Arai-in-residence window makes August the month to go, and booking is essential (when reservations opened in January the earliest table was two months out).¹

Jiin Omakase at Shaw Centre is the Les Amis Group's new Japanese counter — the group behind three-Michelin-star Les Amis — open since 8 May, its talking point a mini ise-ebi (spiny lobster) hotpot finished as lobster *pao fan*. Reviewers converge on “high-end but deliberately unstuffy,” praising the *omotenashi* hospitality; the mild dissent is that it is less rigidly traditional than a purist counter — a feature for some, a quibble for others. Lunch from S\$138, dinner from S\$288++.²

Two for the weekend and the family. **Visitors Café**, a Seoul-Seongsu-style Korean café from the Noci Pasta Bar team near Tanjong Pagar, is airy, minimalist and pet-friendly alfresco — the iced Visitors Cream Latte (S\$8) leads, items roughly S\$7–S\$18; reviewers like the drinks and the Korea-without-the-flight mood, but flag that it is small and crowded from about 11am and carb-heavy. And **Yi Man Fen “Sugar Rush”** at 313@Somerset is the viral Chinese dessert chain's first overseas outlet, opened 15 July — freshly made sweet soups and shaved ice, kid-friendly, mostly takeaway with tight seating, and genuinely too new to judge on food.³

BOOK NOW: SUSHI ARAI

TOO NEW: SUGAR RUSH

THE SCEPTIC — THE TABLE

Read the four honestly. Sushi Arai is the clearest recommendation, but note the peg is the Arai-in-residence window, not a new opening — the restaurant has been open since February, so “book now” means book for the master, not for novelty. Jiin has a track record and settled praise. Visitors and Sugar Rush are young — one crowded, one riding a viral wave — so treat their “buzz” as anticipation, not a verdict, and go with low expectations of a table. Book the pedigree; queue the rest.

THE BUZZ — WHAT THEY ACTUALLY SAY

Only two carry a settled verdict: Sushi Arai (proven Ginza pedigree, and a named master at the counter through September) and Jiin (Les Amis polish, warm reviews). Visitors is loved for its mood but small and busy; Sugar Rush is riding China hype and is too new to call. The honest one-line book-now: Arai, for the window.

SOURCES 1 Tatler Asia; Semba Corp press release, 16 Feb; Time Out SG, Feb 2026 (Ginza Sushi Arai, Parkroyal Collection Marina Bay; first overseas outpost; Toyosu-flown seafood; chef Junpeng Wang under founder Hiroyuki Arai; master Arai at the SG counter Jul–Sep; 8 counter + 6-seat room; one seating nightly 6.30pm, Tue–Sun; S\$398++; opened Feb 2026, soft-launch 15 Jan; earliest table ~2 months out when booking opened Jan). 2 HungryGoWhere; Honeycombers; Ordinary Patrons, May 2026 (Jiin Omakase, Shaw Centre, Les Amis Group, opened 8 May; ise-ebi hotpot / lobster pao fan; lunch from S\$138, dinner from S\$288++; “high-end but unstuffy,” *omotenashi* praised; mild dissent — less rigidly traditional). 3 DanielFoodDiary, 26 May; HungryGoWhere (Visitors Café, near Tanjong Pagar, Seongsu-style, from the Noci Pasta Bar team; iced Visitors Cream Latte S\$8; ~S\$7–18/item; pet-friendly; small/crowded from ~11am, carb-heavy); Eatbook; HungryGoWhere, Jul 2026 (Yi Man Fen “Sugar Rush,” 313@Somerset, first overseas outlet, opened 15 Jul; fresh sweet soups/shaved ice; kid-friendly; mostly takeaway, tight seating; too new to judge).

THE LONG READ · ENERGY & EMPIRE

The Admiral's Bargain

In 1911 Winston Churchill chose to run the Royal Navy on oil it did not have instead of the coal it did – trading British security for foreign speed, and buying an oil company to cover the risk. Every leap in power since has struck the same bargain. This week's version runs on electricity, and the reader is paying its first instalment.

The decision that shaped a century of geopolitics looked, at the time, like an engineering choice about ships. In 1911 Winston Churchill, newly installed as First Lord of the Admiralty, inherited a question his admirals had circled for years: whether to build the Navy's next battleships to burn oil rather than coal.¹ Coal was the safe answer. Britain sat on mountains of it, hewn from Welsh valleys by British miners, secure behind the Royal Navy from any blockade. Oil the fleet would have to import, most of it from Persia, across seas an enemy could cut. To choose oil was to trade a fuel the country controlled for one it did not.

But oil won on performance, and performance wins wars. An oil-fired ship was faster off the mark and faster at a cruise, ran farther on a given weight of fuel, needed fewer hands below, and could be refuelled at sea rather than sitting in port for days while stokers shovelled. Admiral John Fisher, who had preached oil for a decade, put it plainly: a fleet that burned oil could outrun and out-turn one that burned coal. Churchill, persuaded, made the leap – the new Queen Elizabeth-class dreadnoughts, laid down in 1912, would burn oil alone, with no coal bunkers at all.¹ The most powerful warships on earth would run on a fuel the empire could not produce.

To choose oil was to trade a fuel the country controlled for one it did not.

What made the gamble worth it was a naval arms race. Germany was laying down dreadnoughts nearly

as fast as Britain, and a margin of two or three knots – the difference oil could buy – was the margin between dictating a battle and being dragged into one. Coaling was the fleet's great weakness: refuelling a battleship took most of a day, hundreds of men black to the elbows heaving sacks while the ship sat helpless in harbour. Oil flowed through a hose, and could be taken on at sea. The Navy that burned it kept the initiative; the one that burned coal was forever stopping to catch its breath. Churchill was not buying a marginal upgrade. He was buying the first move.

Churchill knew exactly what he was buying and what he was mortgaging. To base the fleet on oil, he later wrote, was "to take arms against a sea of troubles" – and the trouble was supply.² His answer was ownership. In 1914 he drove the British government to buy a controlling 51 per cent stake in the Anglo-Persian Oil Company – the firm that would become BP – so that the Navy's fuel would be, if not British soil, then at least a British asset.² An upgrade to the speed of the fleet had just made His Majesty's Government the majority owner of a Middle Eastern oil company. The bargain was sealed: more capability, in exchange for a permanent dependency, hedged by a stake in the source.

A performance upgrade to the fleet made the government the majority owner of a Middle Eastern oil company.

SOURCES ¹ Daniel Yergin, *The Prize: The Epic Quest for Oil, Money & Power* (1991), ch. 11; Royal Navy / Churchill Archives (Churchill appointed First Lord of the Admiralty, Oct 1911); Admiral John "Jacky" Fisher's decade-long advocacy for oil firing; the Queen Elizabeth-class super-dreadnoughts, laid down 1912, the first British capital ships designed to burn oil only – greater speed, range and at-sea refuelling than coal). ² Winston Churchill, *The World Crisis* (on committing the Navy to oil, "to take arms against a sea of troubles"); Anglo-Persian Oil Company agreement, 20 May 1914; Churchill's June 1914 bill, ~£2.2m for a controlling ~51% government stake in APOC (the forerunner of BP) to secure the Navy's fuel supply.

The bargain has a shape, and once you see it you see it everywhere. A new capability arrives that is plainly superior — faster ships, then the combustion engine, then the electric grid, now artificial intelligence — and it runs on a fuel or an input you do not fully control. You take it anyway, because your rivals will, and refusing keeps you safe and slow while they turn dangerous and fast. The dependency is not a flaw in the upgrade; it is the price of it. What Churchill did with oil, every ambitious power since has done with whatever the next leap demanded — and the leap is never optional once someone else has made it.

This issue is that bargain, struck four times over. The war on p3 is the direct descendant of Churchill's choice: a century of Western fleets and economies tied to Gulf oil is why a missile near Hormuz moves the price of everything, and why the fighting this week reached a gas terminal in Egypt. The market on p15 is watching the newest version of the same trade — an AI-cloud boom whose real constraint is neither chips nor capital but electricity, with Amazon's data-centre revenue alone growing 37 per cent in a quarter.¹ And the technology desk on p7 is the sovereignty fight the bargain always breeds: who owns the chips, who owns the model, who can be cut off from the input. Speed for dependency, four times, on four desks.

The dependency is not a flaw in the upgrade. It is the price of it.

And the reader is paying the first instalment himself. Singapore has made Churchill's exact wager at national scale: it is building an AI-and-data-centre economy — the capability no serious economy can now refuse — on an island that generates about

ninety-five per cent of its electricity from imported natural gas, the fuel it does not control.² This week the two halves of that bet met on a single utility bill: household power up seventeen per cent, tracking gas prices lifted by the same Gulf war (p5), in the very week the trade ministry folded the word “energy” into its name. Britain bought an oil company to hedge its dependency; Singapore diversifies its gas suppliers and courts power imports to hedge its own. The instrument changes across a century. The bargain does not.

Notice what the bargain can do to a balance sheet. Britain's stake in Anglo-Persian was not strategy alone — it became one of the better investments the Treasury ever made, throwing off dividends for decades and seeding the firm that grew into BP. The dependency, owned rather than merely suffered, turned into an asset. That is the sophisticated version of the trade and the one worth copying: since you cannot avoid needing the input, you take a position in it — a long supply contract, an equity stake, a strategic reserve — and convert a vulnerability into a holding. The naive version takes the capability and prays the fuel keeps flowing. The wiser version buys a piece of the well.

The naive version prays the fuel keeps flowing. The wiser version buys a piece of the well.

The same bargain, a century apart

1911 · COAL · OIL

Capability: a faster battle-fleet

The input you don't control: Persian oil

The hedge: 51% of Anglo-Persian Oil

Speed bought a century in the Gulf

2026 · GRID · AI

Capability: an AI-and-data-centre economy

The input you don't control: imported gas

The hedge: supplier variety, power imports

Compute bought a +17% power bill

A Meridian original. The same trade — capability for a fuel you don't own — struck twice.

A battle-fleet's oil and a data-centre's electricity are the same wager: take the capability, import the fuel, and hedge the dependency you cannot escape.

Britain bought an oil company. Singapore diversifies its gas. The instrument changes; the bargain does not.

SOURCES ¹ The World, p3 (the Gulf war and Hormuz); The Macro Desk, p15 (Amazon AWS +37% YoY, the AI-cloud build-out whose binding constraint is electricity); Technology, p7 (chip- and model-sovereignty). Daniel Yergin, *The Prize*, on the century of Gulf-oil dependency that followed the naval conversion. ² Singapore, p5; EMA / SP Group (Singapore generates ~95% of its electricity from imported natural gas; the household tariff up 17% for Jul-Sep 2026, tracking gas prices lifted by Middle East conflict incl. Hormuz disruption; MTI renamed the Ministry of Energy, Trade and Industry). Cross-desk synthesis is Meridian's own.

Here is the lesson, and it is not “avoid the dependency.” Churchill was right. Coal would have left the Royal Navy slower than the German fleet, and a safe, slow navy loses; the reader can no more opt out of AI than Britain could opt out of oil. The enterprises and nations that refuse a capability to stay independent simply lose to the ones that take it and manage the exposure. The trade is almost always worth making. What separates Churchill’s wisdom from mere recklessness is the second half of his thinking — the hedge, and the clarity about the bill.

His prescription was a single word: variety. “Safety and certainty in oil,” he told Parliament in 1913, “lie in variety, and variety alone” — not in any one field, supplier or contract, but in never depending on one.¹ It is, strikingly, the same instruction a modern portfolio gives. The reader’s own defence against any single market is a globally-diversified fund — variety, and variety alone (p15) — and Singapore’s answer to an import-dependent grid is more suppliers, not a fantasy of self-sufficiency. The principle scales from a battle-fleet’s fuel to a saver’s equities to a city-state’s power: you cannot escape dependence, so you spread it, name it and price it. The failure is never striking the bargain. It is striking it blind — taking the speed and pretending the bill will not arrive.

History is unkind to the powers that took the capability and skipped the hedge. The armies that motorised without securing oil spent the next war rationing it; the firms that bet everything on a single supplier learned the meaning of leverage the day that supplier raised its price or a government revoked its licence. The technology desk on p7 is the live case: the best open AI model on earth is Chinese, and the American silicon that would run it best cannot be sold into the country that built it — a mutual dependency each side is now scrambling, a beat too late, to hedge. The bill always arrives. The only real question is whether you saw it coming and put something aside.

You cannot escape the dependence. So you spread it, name it, and price it.

Which is what makes this week’s small Singapore number worth more than its size. A seventeen-per-cent power bill is not a crisis; it is an invoice, and an honest one — the first visible instalment on an ambition the whole island has embraced. Churchill’s navy paid for its speed in a century of Gulf entanglement that is still being settled, in missiles, this very week (p3). The bet was still correct. The wisdom was in seeing the cost from the start and building the hedge before the reckoning, rather than being surprised by a bill that was always coming.

FROM THE DESK

“Safety and certainty in oil lie in variety, and variety alone.”

— Winston Churchill, House of Commons, 17 July 1913¹

The whole issue runs on that sentence. A war over an oil chokepoint (p3), a data-centre boom hungry for power (p15), a Singapore electricity bill (p5) — each is a bargain struck for capability against a fuel someone else controls. Churchill’s answer, a century on, is still the only good one: not independence, which is impossible, but variety, which is a discipline. It is the same word the Macro desk gives the reader for his own portfolio.

THE SCEPTIC

Do not let the analogy carry more than it can. Churchill’s was a single state’s monopoly decision in a two-fuel world; today’s energy-and-compute dependencies are more diffuse, with more suppliers, more substitutes, and a genuine — if slow — shift toward power a nation can build at home, solar and nuclear, a hedge Churchill never had. And “the trade is always worth it” is exactly how every over-leveraged bet is justified right up until it isn’t. The honest reading is narrower than the sweep of a century: capability and dependency arrive together, the wise buyer diversifies the dependency early, and a power bill is a small, real reminder that the ambitions of an age are paid for in the fuel of an age.

SOURCES ¹ Winston Churchill, speech to the House of Commons, 17 July 1913 (“Safety and certainty in oil lie in variety, and variety alone,” on securing the Navy’s oil supply — Hansard / Churchill Archives). Cross-references: The Macro Desk, p15 (a globally-diversified fund as the reader’s own “variety”); Singapore, p5 (supplier diversification and power imports for an import-dependent grid); The World, p3 (the still-unsettled Gulf entanglement that followed the West’s century on oil). Historical synthesis and the coal-to-oil analogy are Meridian’s own; the naval and Anglo-Persian facts are sourced on pp21–22.

This issue has a single fuel line running through it. A war widened over an oil chokepoint and reached a gas terminal in Egypt; a Singapore electricity bill rose seventeen per cent because the island imports the gas that lights it; the market's loudest number was a cloud business growing thirty-seven per cent on an appetite measured in megawatts; and the chips and models everyone wants are the sovereignty fights that dependency always breeds. The essay reaches back to 1911, when Churchill ran the Royal Navy on oil it did not have because coal it did have was too slow — and bought an oil company to cover the bet. That is the standing bargain of every age: you buy the capability and you rent the fuel, from someone, somewhere. His one instruction still holds, for a fleet, a grid or a portfolio — safety lies in variety, and variety alone. Take the speed. See the bill. Spread the risk before the reckoning, not after it.

CONSOLIDATED SOURCES — NO. 58

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The Long Read (The Admiral's Bargain): Daniel Yergin, *The Prize* (1991); Winston Churchill, *The World Crisis*; Royal Navy / Churchill Archives; Anglo-Persian Oil Company records; Hansard (Commons, 17 Jul 1913); cross-desk synthesis (pp3, 5, 7, 15).